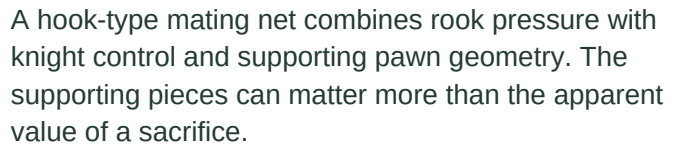


Hook mating nets

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES



Identify the final checking line and then trace which friendly pieces protect the attacker and control the king's exits.

The defending king is on d3. Geometrically undefended: knight on h4. Check for tactical protection.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

39...Rd2+ Check restricts White to 1 legal reply here. Recorded reply: **40.Ke3.**

40...d4+ Check restricts White to 1 legal reply here. Recorded reply: **41.Kf3**.

41...Rf2# Mate: rook on f2 gives check; White has no legal reply.

The line ends in checkmate against the king on f3. Material gain is unnecessary once no legal defense exists.

Which piece delivers the final check, and why can the defender not continue? **Answer:** Rook on f2. The king is in check and the position has zero legal replies.

Recount the king's legal replies after each move. A changed pawn placement can destroy an otherwise familiar mating pattern.